

Attachment 4

Principal Investigator's Assessment of the Ethical Nature of the Research

To Renounce Liberty? A Public-Goods Experiment on (Un)Democratic Reversal

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Assessment

The study involves approximately 400 adults who voluntarily participate in one paid, approximately 60-minute laboratory session. Participants make anonymous, incentivised decisions in a fictional public-service setting. The study does not use deception about the rules or payment calculation, collect biological samples, intervene in physical integrity, expose participants to unusually strong stimuli, or target children or other groups whose capacity to consent is impaired.

Foreseeable burdens are limited to waiting in a synchronized task and possible mild discomfort with a crisis scenario or unequal point allocations. Participants receive plain-language information and a privacy notice before giving electronic consent. They may decline or stop without giving a reason or suffering negative consequences. The laboratory manager monitors the session, provides procedural assistance, and manages any interruption without generating decisions on a participant's behalf.

The task is scientifically necessary because the research question concerns consequential choices, repeated interaction, and whether the same participant changes an institutional decision after conditions change. The design minimises burden through one visit, unpaid practice, comprehension checks, neutral wording, and payment of EUR 10 plus a performance bonus of up to EUR 5.

Privacy and data protection

The production oTree study and coded research data are hosted on University of Turku IT servers in Finland. PCRC retains the identifying information needed for recruitment and payment and gives the research team only coded data. Its temporary identity-to-code link is deleted when compensation has been paid. Access to coded research data is restricted to Janne Tukiainen, Hector Bahamonde, and authorised personnel. Results are reported without identifying participants. Coded data may be retained for verification and compatible future scientific research as described in the privacy notice and data management plan.

The short questionnaire may indirectly reveal political opinions; these answers are therefore handled conservatively as special-category personal data. Data minimisation, separation of identities, restricted access, secure University storage, disclosure review, and aggregate reporting reduce the residual risk. The final data-protection arrangements and the need for a formal DPIA will be confirmed with the University Data Protection Officer before data collection.

Conclusion

In my assessment, the protocol's scientific value is proportionate to its limited foreseeable risks and burdens. The participant information, consent procedure, compensation, laboratory safeguards, and data-protection measures support voluntary and informed participation. Data collection will begin only after the required ethical and institutional approvals are in place.

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